

Imputed Righteousness

doc-imputed-righteousness

Soteriology · Justification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.932
confidence high

Statement under examination

In justification, the believer is reckoned righteous before God on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer.

In plain language

The proposition asks whether God reckons a person righteous in justification on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, rather than on the basis of righteousness already inside the person. The key Greek verb is *logizomai*, an accounting word that the lexicon defines as to count or reckon, to take into account. It appears across thirty nine verses, eleven of them in Romans 4 alone. In that chapter Paul even uses it commercially in verse 4, where a worker's pay is reckoned to his account, which fixes the sense as crediting rather than producing. He quotes Genesis 15.6 twice, in Romans 4 and Galatians 3, where God counts Abraham's faith as righteousness, the Hebrew verb there being *chashav*, which likewise means to count or reckon. The decisive line is Romans 4.5: God justifies the ungodly, the *asebes*, the one who is not working but believing. If the person being justified is at that moment ungodly, the righteousness credited cannot already be a quality inside him. Romans 4.6 adds apart from works, and Romans 4.8 shows the same accounting can withhold the charge of sin. 2 Corinthians 5.21 says we become God's righteousness in him, placing the righteousness in Christ, and Philippians 3.9 contrasts my own righteousness from law with the righteousness from God by faith. The Old Testament agrees: Jeremiah 23.6 names the Branch the Lord our righteousness, binding the people's righteousness to another, and Isaiah 53.11 says the Servant justifies many while bearing their guilt. So the words clearly say the righteousness is reckoned, not generated from the believer. Where readers diverge is the next question the words leave open: what exactly is the reckoned thing, Christ's own obedience credited, the faith itself counted, a shared righteousness by union, or a righteousness later worked in. The verb settles the accounting but not its content, and the verb constitute in Romans 5.19 usually means to install in an office, which is the seam a transformation reading uses.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0539	וְאָמֵן	aman	be faithful	
H0835	אֲשֶׁרִי	esher	blessed	
H2803	חָשַׁב	chashav	to devise	124
H3068	יְהוָה	YHWH	LORD	6,828
H5445	יָסַבֵּל	saval	to bear	
H6588	פָּשַׁע	pesah	transgression	
H6663	צָדִיק	tsadaq	to justify	41
H6664	צֶדֶק	tsedeq	righteousness	119
H6666	צִדְקָה	tsedaqah	righteousness	157

G0011	Ἀβραάμ	Abraam	Abraham	73
G0266	ἁμαρτίαν	hamartia	sin	
G0268	ἁμαρτωλοὶ	hamartōlos	sinful	
G0765	ἄσεβῆς	asebes	ungodly	9
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	76
G1343	δικαιοσύνη	dikaiosune	righteousness	87
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioo	to justify	35
G2038	ἐργαζομένω	ergazomai	to work	
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	177
G2316	θεοῦ	theos	God	
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistemi	to appoint/conduct	21
G3049	λογίζομαι	logizomai	to count	39
G3107	μακάριος	makarios	blessed	50
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	251

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The load bearing verb is λογίζομαι (G3049), an accounting term glossed in the lexicon as to count, reckon, take into account, and used by Paul across 39 verses in the canon, eleven of them in Romans 4 alone (vv 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10, 11, 22, 23, 24, confirmed by direct query). Paul quotes Gen 15.6 (Hebrew **בשרי**, the same calculate or reckon verb, rendered ἐλογίσθη in the LXX) twice, in Rom 4.3 and Gal 3.6, and Ps 32.1 in Rom 4.7 to 4.8, grounding the pattern in two Old Testament witnesses. Rom 4.5 pairs the verb with τὸν ἄσεβῆ (the ungodly) and Rom 4.6 adds χωρὶς ἔργων (apart from works), so the righteousness reckoned at that moment is a status distinct from the person's inherent state. 2 Cor 5.21 (γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ) locates the righteousness ἐν αὐτῷ (in Christ), and Phil 3.9 opposes ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην ἐκ νόμου to τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην. The verb says the righteousness is reckoned, not produced, so the proposition stands. The text fixes the accounting mechanism but leaves the precise content and source of the reckoned righteousness underdetermined, which is where readers diverge.

Scripture

Rom.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 ἐπίστευσεν, G3049 ἐλογίσθη, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G0011 Ἀβραάμ

Force. Paul quotes Gen 15.6 LXX verbatim, ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην. The aorist passive ἐλογίσθη with the preposition εἰς names a divine act of reckoning into someone's account. Faith on Abraham's side is the occasion, and righteousness is what is placed to his account. The lexicon (Abbott-Smith) classes this εἰς construction under to reckon, take into account, mirroring the Hebrew **ל** with **בשרי**,

Rom.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2038 ἐργαζομένω, G3049 λογίζεται

Force. Paul sets the wage paradigm (κατὰ ὀφείλημα, according to debt) against the χάρις paradigm. To the one working, the pay is not reckoned (λογίζεται) as grace but as obligation. The same accounting verb is used in a clearly commercial sense here, which fixes its sense as crediting to an account rather than producing a quality.

Rom.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογίζεται, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G4100 πιστεύοντι, G0765 άσεβή, G1344 δικαιούντα

Force. The decisive verse. To the one not working but believing on the one who justifies (δικαιούντα) the ungodly (άσεβή), his faith is reckoned (λογίζεται) for righteousness. The object of the justifying verb is explicitly the ungodly, the άσεβής, a word the lexicon glosses ungodly, impious. If the person justified is at that moment ungodly, the righteousness reckoned cannot be a quality already inherent in him.

Rom.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογίζεται, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G2041 έργων

Force. David pronounces blessing on the person to whom God reckons righteousness apart from works (χωρίς έργων). The χωρίς construction excludes the believer's own deeds as the basis of the reckoning. The verb λογίζεται keeps its accounting sense and the subject is ό θεός, God credits.

Rom.4.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3107 μακάριος, G3049 λογίσθαι, G0266 άμαρτίαν

Force. Quoting Ps 32.2 LXX, blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will not reckon (ού μη λογίσθαι). The negative use shows λογίζομαι is an act of accounting that God can apply or withhold independent of the person's own state. Non reckoning of sin and reckoning of righteousness are the two sides of the same forensic operation.

Gal.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 έπίστευσεν, G3049 έλογίσθη, G1343 δικαιοσύνην

Force. Paul quotes Gen 15.6 a second time, έλογίσθη αύτῷ εις δικαιοσύνην, in a separate letter and argument. The independent reuse of the same reckoning formula in Galatians as in Romans shows the pattern is not a single contextual flourish but a settled lexical reading of Genesis across the Pauline corpus.

Rom.3.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογιζόμεθα, G1344 δικαιούσθαι, G2041 έργων

Force. Paul binds the three terms together, λογιζόμεθα γάρ δικαιούσθαι πίστει άνθρωπον χωρίς έργων νόμου, a person is justified (δικαιούσθαι) by faith apart from works of law. The justifying verb and the apart from works qualifier appear in one clause, confirming the basis of the verdict is not the person's performance.

Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 κατεστάθησαν, G2525 κατασταθήσονται, G0268 άμαρτωλοί, G1342 δίκαιοι

Force. Parallel passive constructions. Through the disobedience of the one, the many were constituted (κατεστάθησαν) sinners. Through the obedience of the one, the many will be constituted (κατασταθήσονται) righteous. The verb καθίστημι is glossed in the lexicon as to set in order, appoint, make, constitute, and elsewhere in the canon it appoints to office (Matt 24.45, Luke 12.42, Acts 6.3, Heb 5.1). Here the passive plus federal one to many structure denotes status assignment by representation, but the verb itself does not specify whether the constituting is purely declarative or also transformative, which is the lexical seam readers exploit.

2Cor.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 άμαρτίαν, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. The exchange clause. The one not knowing sin (μη γνόντα άμαρτίαν) God made sin on our behalf, so that we might become God's righteousness in him (γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ έν αύτῷ). The verb is γίνομαι, become, and the locative έν αύτῷ places the righteousness in Christ. The clause says we become this righteousness in him, which the words leave open between a credited status held in Christ and a participatory share in Christ's own righteousness.

Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G4100 πίστεως, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. Paul opposes ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐκ νόμου (my own righteousness from law) to τὴν διὰ πίστεως Χριστοῦ, τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει (the righteousness from God through the faith of Christ, on the basis of faith). The stacked prepositions ἐκ θεοῦ, διὰ πίστεως, ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει locate the source of the righteousness in God and exclude the apostle's own performance as its basis. The phrase πίστεως Χριστοῦ is itself a known genitive ambiguity, faith in Christ or the faithfulness of Christ, but either reading keeps the righteousness ἐκ θεοῦ.

Gen.15.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0539 וַיִּחְשַׁב, H2803 וַיַּחְשְׁבָהּ, H6666 חָשַׁב

Force. Abraham believed (וַיִּחְשַׁב) in YHWH and he counted it to him (וַיַּחְשְׁבָהּ) as righteousness (חָשַׁב). The verb חָשַׁב, attested 124 times in the Old Testament, is glossed count, think, devise, design. In Gen 15.6 the accounting sense, counted it to him, is in view, the same sense the LXX captured with ἐλογίσθη. This is the source pattern Paul quotes in Rom 4 and Gal 3 and James cites in Jas 2.23.

Ps.32.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0835 אָשַׁר, H6588 שָׁשַׁע

Force. Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven and whose sin is covered. Paul reads this Davidic blessing in Rom 4.7 to 4.8 as the non reckoning of sin that runs parallel to the reckoning of righteousness, so that the same divine accounting both withholds the charge of sin and credits righteousness.

Jer.23.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H6664 חָשַׁב

Force. The messianic Branch is named יְהוָה חָשַׁב (YHWH our righteousness). The noun חָשַׁב carries the first common plural suffix נוּ, our, binding the people's righteousness to the person of the Branch. The people's righteousness is named as residing in another, a prophetic parallel to the New Testament righteousness lodged ἐν αὐτῷ.

Isa.53.11 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6663 יָצַדִּיק, H5445 יָסַב

Force. The Servant will justify (יָצַדִּיק, hiphil of צָדַק, declarative, make or declare righteous) the many, and their iniquities he will bear (יָסַב, to carry a load). The hiphil of צָדַק denotes the Servant's declarative justification of others while he simultaneously carries their guilt, the prophetic substrate of the New Testament exchange. The lexicon glosses the verb יָצַדִּיק as to justify.

Jas.2.24 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιούται, G2041 ἔργων, G4100 πίστεως

Force. James writes that a person is justified (δικαιούται) by works and not by faith alone. At the lexical surface this looks opposed to Paul. The verb δικαιώ carries two attested senses in the canon, to show or prove righteous and to declare or pronounce righteous (lexicon entry on G1344). James 2.23 quotes the same Gen 15.6 ἐλογίσθη formula, so the reckoning verb λογίζομαι is common ground. The divergence sits in which sense of δικαιώ is operative, demonstrative for James, declarative for Paul.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.4.3	Gen.15.6	tsk	1
Rom.4.5	Rom.4.3	tsk	1
Rom.4.6	Rom.4.11	tsk	1

Rom.4.7	Ps.32.1	tsk	1
Rom.4.8	Isa.53.10	tsk	1
2Cor.5.21	Isa.53.4	tsk	1
2Cor.5.21	Isa.53.9	tsk	1
Phil.3.9	Phil.3.6	tsk	1
Jer.23.6	Jer.33.16	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jas.2.24 · addressed

James 2.21 to 2.23 cites the same Gen 15.6 ἐλογίσθη formula that anchors Romans 4. The chronology in Genesis places the reckoning of Gen 15.6 decades before the offering of Isaac in Gen 22, so James cannot mean the works produced the reckoning. The lexicon shows δικαιώ carries both a demonstrative sense, to show to be righteous (Matt 11.19, Luke 7.35), and a declarative forensic sense, to pronounce righteous (Rom 3.24, 3.28, 4.5). James uses the demonstrative sense, the works vindicate the faith already reckoned, while Paul uses the forensic sense. The reckoning verb λογίζομαι is identical in both, so the two are lexically compatible.

Jas.2.21 · addressed

Same lexical resolution. James asks whether Abraham was justified by works when he offered Isaac. James 2.23 immediately quotes Gen 15.6 with the ἐλογίσθη formula, framing the Akedah as the fulfilment of the prior reckoning rather than its ground. The dual sense of δικαιώ, demonstrative for James and declarative for Paul, holds the two strands together at the word level.

Rom.2.13 · addressed

Paul writes that the doers of the law will be justified (δικαιωθήσονται). In the immediate flow Rom 2.1 to 3.20, Paul is establishing that no one in fact meets this standard, reaching the universal verdict of Rom 3.19 to 3.20 that no flesh is justified by works of law. The verse states the principle that would justify if anyone could keep it, then Paul shows none can, before introducing the alternative basis in Rom 3.21 to 4.25. The lexical pattern of reckoned righteousness is not disturbed.

Matt.25.46 · addressed

The judgement of the nations scene appears to make lived works the basis of final acceptance, with οἱ δίκαιοι entering eternal life. The pericope evaluates obedience as evidence of belonging, and the lexical anchors of the reckoning pattern, λογίζομαι and δικαιώ paired with ἀσεβῆ and χωρὶς ἔργων, are absent here. The Matthean evidential strand and the Pauline forensic strand address different aspects of judgement and do not collide at the word level.

Rom.5.19 · unaddressed

Although this verse supports the verdict, it carries an unresolved lexical openness worth flagging. The verb καθίστημι (G2525) is glossed appoint, make, constitute, and in 20 of its 21 canon occurrences it installs someone in an office or role (Matt 24.45, Luke 12.42, Acts 6.3, Heb 5.1, 7.28). Rom 5.19 is its only justification context use. The passive κατασταθήσονται therefore does not, by the word alone, settle whether the many are constituted righteous purely by reckoned status or also by an effected transformation. The verse is consistent with the reckoning pattern but the single verb cannot by itself foreclose the transformative reading, so the openness is recorded rather than papered over.

Concordance traversed

G3049, G1344, G1343, G1342, G2525, G0765, G4100, G2041, G3107, H2803, H6666, H6664, H6663

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

rom4.8-ou-hou at Rom.4.8: impact none. The relative pronoun variation, οὗ against ᾧ, in the citation of Ps 32.2 LXX does not alter the verb λογίσσεται or the negation οὐ μή. The clause still teaches God's non reckoning of sin under either reading.

2cor5.21-ton-art at 2Cor.5.21: impact none. The τὸν article variation at the head of the verse does not change the participial clause μὴ γνόντα ἁμαρτίαν or the purpose clause ἵνα γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ. The exchange logic holds under either reading.

rom10.3-idian at Rom.10.3: impact none. The ἰδίαν reading (their own righteousness) bears on the contrast between God's righteousness and self righteousness but does not touch the cited anchor verses or the reckoning verb. Listed only to confirm the broader chain is variant stable.

All anchor verses are in the Pauline epistles, Genesis, Psalms, Isaiah and Jeremiah, none of which fall in the ingested ECM published window (3 John). The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true. SBLGNT, the MorphGNT verse text queried from the store, and standard editions agree on the substantive anchors λογίζομαι, δικαιοσύνη, δικαιώω, ἄσεβής and καθίστημι in the cited verses, so the verdict is not variant sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_perspective_on_paul, participationist_union_with_christ, infused_transformation_reading

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

forensic_imputation_reading: affirms · Reads λογίζομαι in Rom 4 as a courtroom and ledger metaphor of crediting. The accounting sense fixed by Rom 4.4 (wage versus grace), the object τὸν ἄσεβῃ in Rom 4.5, the qualifier χωρὶς ἔργων in Rom 4.6, and the parallel passives of Rom 5.19 are read as a reckoned status assigned to the believer, with the specific content being Christ's own righteousness or obedience credited to the account. On this reading the righteousness is alien, not inherent.

faith_itself_reckoned_reading: affirms · Takes the grammar of Rom 4.3 and 4.5 at face value, his faith is reckoned for righteousness, and holds that what God credits is the believer's faith counted as righteousness rather than a transfer of Christ's distinct obedience. This still satisfies the proposition, the righteousness is reckoned and rests on Christ's work received by faith and is not an inherent moral quality, but it locates the reckoned item differently. The text states the act of reckoning plainly but does not spell out whether the thing reckoned is Christ's obedience or the faith itself, so this reading is lexically available.

participationist_union_with_christ: affirms · Emphasises ἐν αὐτῷ in 2 Cor 5.21 and Phil 3.9 and the wider ἐν Χριστῷ language. The believer becomes God's righteousness by union, sharing in Christ's righteousness rather than receiving an infused personal quality. This reading converges with the forensic one on the central claim, the righteousness is not the believer's own inherent property, and it foregrounds the locative phrases the text actually uses.

new_perspective_on_paul: partial · Reads δικαιώω primarily as covenant membership or vindication language and takes works of the law in Rom 3 and 4 to mean ethnic boundary markers rather than meritorious works in general. On this lens Rom 4 chiefly answers who belongs to Abraham's family. Even so, the reckoning of righteousness to the ungodly in Rom 4.5 remains a granted status rather than an inherent one, so the proposition that righteousness is reckoned and not inherent still holds, while the precise meaning of the reckoned righteousness is read covenantally. The dual sense of δικαιώω noted in the lexicon, declare or vindicate, gives this lens its lexical foothold.

infused_transformation_reading: denies · Reads the reckoning as God recognising or initiating a real righteousness worked into the believer by grace, drawing on the dominant office installing sense of καθίστημι (constitute, make actually) in Rom 5.19 and on the become language of γίνομαι in 2 Cor 5.21. On this lens justification names a making righteous, not only a counting righteous. The reading must construe Rom 4.5 (justifies the ungodly) as the inception of an infusion and must soften χωρὶς ἔργων. The accounting force of λογίζομαι, its commercial use in Rom 4.4, and the explicit ἄσεβῃ object pull against this at the surface, which is why the verdict

on the proposition is affirms while this lens is recorded fairly as the dissenting reading.

The verdict turns on the accounting sense of λογίζομαι plus the ἀσεβῆ object plus the χωρίς ἔργων qualifier, which together establish that righteousness is reckoned rather than produced from the believer's own state. What the vocabulary does not settle is the content and source of the reckoned righteousness, whether Christ's distinct obedience, the believer's faith counted as righteousness, a participatory share by union, or covenant standing. The redemptive historical method is primary because the verdict runs along the Genesis to Isaiah to Pauline arc, with Gen 15.6 and Isa 53.11 as the substrate.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. On what basis does God reckon or declare a person righteous in justification: on the basis of righteousness located in Christ and received by faith, on the basis of the person's faith counted as righteousness, on the basis of righteousness worked inherently into the person, or on some combination?

The stem encodes its own conclusion with the phrases reckoned righteous, Christ's work received by faith, and not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer. The neutralized form opens the question to the full range of defensible answers and lets the lexical data adjudicate. The verdict is derived on the original stem and is affirmed because the accounting verb λογίζομαι (count, reckon), the ungodly object ἀσεβῆ, the χωρίς ἔργων qualifier and the locative ἐν αὐτῷ together support a reckoned and not inherent righteousness. The verdict is unchanged from the prior evidence file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.4.3
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.4.5
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.5.19
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.5.21
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Phil.3.9
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.15.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jer.23.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.53.11
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3049
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1344
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2525
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0765
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2803
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6663
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.4.3-Gen.15.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.4.7-Ps.32.1
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Cor.5.21-Isa.53.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jer.23.6-Jer.33.16
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.4.5
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.15.6

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved